

EXPERIENCES OF EDUCATION

Life lessons

In many societies of the past, women were not expected to be academic. Those who did receive an education found that their lessons were designed to prepare them for religious or married life, rather than the pursuit of knowledge for its own sake.



▲ Writing slate

From the 18th until the 20th century, it was common for girls to use erasable slates—such as this example from the 1890s—in the classroom to learn how to write and do arithmetic.

FOR MUCH OF HISTORY, women did not have the same access to education as men. Women were expected to marry, have children, and, if they were poor, help their husbands by working; they needed no formal schooling for tasks such as farming, doing laundry, or housework. Literacy was often tied to a woman's class and station, and varied greatly between cultures. In ancient Athens and Rome, for example, many women were educated in numeracy because the economies revolved around commerce, and even some slave women were literate.

Assessing female literacy across time does not reveal a simple rising progression—rather it shows that it rose and fell, the latter notably in the medieval period, when levels of female literacy plummeted. Increased urbanization from the 10th century onward was one of the major factors in improving women's education

“Education deserves **emphatically** to be termed **cultivation** of [the] **mind**.”

MARY WOLLSTONECRAFT, 1792

“I am **convinced** that we must **train not only** the **head**, but the **heart** and **hand** as well.”

CHIANG KAI-SHEK, 1940

once more, as women in towns began to need to read, write, and do basic calculations as part of their daily lives. Some women set up small schools—called *Winkelschule* (backstreet schools) in Germany—to teach boys and girls how to read (but not write or do arithmetic). Coeducational schooling like this was especially popular during the Reformation, when such schools taught children to read the Bible.

Finishing schools

In many cultures, women's education focused on what was deemed necessary to make a girl a suitable wife. In the ancient Zhou Dynasty of China, boys and girls were separated in education at the age of 10, after which girls would go on to study the “Three Obediences and Four Virtues.” These virtues were based around how girls should behave once they married; girls were taught how to speak,